

A Language of Threats

Chapter 1

Kafka once swore that if he ever loved someone, he would never bring them to London. To hell with any other city or country, so long as it wasn't London.

London had always seemed to exist beneath a sky the colour of rain. Heavy clouds lingered above the city and swallowed what little sunlight there was. By the time night fell, darkness seemed to spread through every corner of it.

And so it was with Kafka.

His world had always been much the same. No matter how bright things appeared from the outside, there was always something darker waiting beneath it.

Today, he found himself back in the city, back at his family estate. The house was lavish and artistic, its walls adorned with flawlessly detailed carvings.

Some rooms were filled with paintings, others with books. Among them was a first-edition copy of *The Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*. His father, Edward, bought it simply because he shared a given name with the author, *Edward Gibbon*.

In public, he would gush about how much he had read and learned from it. *"I was so taken with the work, you see, I couldn't put it down. Read the whole thing in a matter of days, I did."* Kafka still remembered every single word his father uttered during that interview.

It was all a lie. His father had never so much as touched the book.

That book talked about the collapse of Rome brought on by some factors, factors his father embodied completely. There was no way he would read it.

Besides, his father wasn't even British by birth, he was Czech. Reading that book was useless anyway, as his father believed that the British perspective on Rome was entirely misguided. The fall of Rome? No such thing.

To his father, Rome had always been the ultimate symbol of Central European glory. In blood and history, the Holy Roman Empire once reigned from Prague, *not London*.

That expensive book was nothing more than a mask for his father, meant to make the British forget where he truly came from.

Kafka was certain the people here were no fools—he had believed that for a long time. It wasn't that the people were easily duped by his father. Rather, his father was the one who could make everyone look like a fool.

Outrage flared when his father rose to Prime Minister. The British tabloids tore into Kafka's family lineage, questioning his loyalty and branding him an "*Outsider Running Britain*."

In the UK, the public doesn't vote for a Prime Minister directly. Instead, they vote for the political party that holds the majority in the House of Commons. Edward secured his party's leadership through power consolidation, exploiting his rivals' weaknesses, and promising stability.

Edward had married the daughter of a prominent British family, part of the Howard family. Yet, even after that, Edward refused to drop his surname. In fact, he flaunted it, boldly proclaiming, "I chose Britain because I believe in its greatness."

Because of that, he won over the elite circles and moderate voters alike, he was seen as a self-made success story fiercely devoted to the British system. Some even viewed his presence as something fresh, a beacon of hope that could reshape history.

Back then, Edward was the man stealing every spotlight. He didn't fear hostility. Instead, he managed to twist that hatred into his own display of magnanimous forgiveness.

In Czech literature, the legendary *Good Soldier Švejk* embodies this strategy. He acts utterly submissive and simple-minded to fool foreign rulers while secretly manipulating the system from within.

Edward began adopting the classic British elite lifestyle, sponsoring museums, attending the Royal Ascot races, and residing in an art-filled London townhouse. A chameleon at heart, changing his skin to blend seamlessly into Britain.

Yet, in between all this, Edward also revived the Kafka Company, expanding the family business so rapidly that it gained the full backing of several prominent British families. Operations spanned multiple sectors, with literature, finance, and tourism drawing the most attention. That era of prosperity endured right through to the end of Edward's tenure.

Unfortunately, his father had now decided to transfer ownership of the shares.

If Kafka had any say in the matter, he wanted no part in his family's. Whether it was politics or the family business, it was all equally nauseating to him.

Upon arriving home, the household staff greeted him. Some looked astonished, others shocked, while a few simply bowed their heads.

Kafka ignored them completely. To him, they were nothing more than his father's pawns. No matter how polite they appeared, the moment his father gave an order, they would obey.

"Tell him to wait for me in his room. He needn't bother looking for me—I'll go to him when I'm ready." Kafka unbuttoned his coat without looking at a single face among the staff. He didn't mention a name, not that he bothered to know a single one of them.

"I'd like to get some rest before dealing with him. If he were a human and had an ounce of humanity, he'd let me rest first," Kafka added as he walked toward his room.

Kafka stepped into his room after years away. It remained untouched, unchanged, and clean. The large window was still there, right where he remembered, once one of his favorite spots.

"Is there anything I can—"

"Leaving me alone and keeping your mouth shut would be far more helpful," Kafka held up a sharp, dismissive hand, cutting off the staff member who attempted to tend to him from the doorway.

The staff—probably, a new hire—looked taken aback and hurried away without a word of argument, shutting the door ever so softly, as though the slightest noise might set him off.

Out beyond the glass, however, the birds were never afraid to sing around Kafka. They chirped back and forth, perching on the branches of a tree near his window. He viewed them almost as adversaries. Not out of any actual hatred for birds, but because he envied them.

They were free out there, free to make noise and soar high into the sky. Even if their lives were occasionally in danger, at least their own families weren't the ones threatening them. That was how Kafka saw it.

Threatened.

Perhaps that was why this city felt so suffocating. It wasn't the people, nor was it the weather or anything else. It was his family living in it.

That threat had loomed over him since the day he was born. Like being raised on a battlefield, Kafka had grown accustomed to the constant tension in this house over time. Besides, he was part of the reason for that tension in the first place.

Kafka sat on the chair by the window and closed his eyes. In truth, he had sat in this same spot since he was a boy. Learning to spell, reading books, writing, painting, taking afternoon naps, everything had been done right beside this window.

The sound of the birds lulled him into a calm, though he knew it was only temporary.

When his bedroom door opened for the second time, he didn't need to open his eyes to know who it was. The heavy, distinct footfalls, the firm shove of the door, and the precise way the steps ceased upon reaching their destination.

“Not human after all, I see,” Kafka murmured, slowly opening his eyes. “You really ought to have banned resting in this country back when you were still standing as Prime Minister—”

“—Father,” Kafka gritted his teeth, looking up at him.

It was his father, Edward.

Edward was a tall, imposing figure with a thin mustache and beard, wearing glasses and carrying his signature scent of aged wood. That was his father.

Every now and then, Kafka wished he could deny his own bloodline, wishing he weren't the biological son of this old man. Yet, even from his own facial structure, Kafka knew there was no denying the resemblance.

Edward stared at him for a while, "My son returns home from a long journey, how could I possibly not come to see him right away?"

Kafka had anticipated the response, but he hadn't expected the faint smile hovering at the corner of his father's mouth, or perhaps it was his hallucinations.

Kafka shifted his gaze back toward the window. "Just go wait in your room, I'll be there after I take a rest. You know I've never been one for foolish escapes, something like jumping out the window and running as far as I can will never give me a chance against you. London is your playground, after all."

"And another thing, I reckon it's about time you stopped having your men drag your son back home. I'm far too old to be carried back like a child," Kafka added.

Edward remained standing in the same spot for a moment before slowly sitting on the edge of the bed. Still facing the window, his gaze stayed locked on Kafka.

"I had the staff clean your room every day, but I strictly forbade them from moving a single item," Edward said out of nowhere.

Whatever fairytale he was spinning this time, Kafka tried his best to ignore it.

"Do you like it? I hope you do. I want you back home, son ... It worries me sick seeing you drift aimlessly from one country to another..." Edward brushed his hand against the bedsheet.

“When your uncle mentioned you were coming home, I told the staff to stand by near your room. You still enjoy a warm bath, don't you? Just say the word and they'll draw one for you. Ah, or perhaps you prefer a proper shower these days? I can have them fit in one of your bathrooms later.”

Kafka laughed once under his breath, though there was nothing amused about it. “Having successfully passed yourself off as British, are you trying to play the Asian now? Showering twice a day hardly suits the climate in this city.”

“Ah...” Edward nodded slowly. “Forgive me. I quite forgot... playing the Asian is your area of expertise, isn't it? Heaven forbid I compete with you.”

Kafka had just dug his own grave. He scoffed and looked at his father as though he could hardly believe what he had just heard.

Edward wasn't about to stop there. He pressed on, “I hear you've set up a business over there. Not a bad move! I'm so proud of you, really, establishing your own media and news company ... though its voice is barely a mosquito's buzz, at least you've managed to build your own little empire, haven't you?”

“Why not the US instead? New York, perhaps? I have a few acquaintances over there who could give you a leg up. I know you haven't got much of a trust there, just say the word, what is it you need?” Edward leaned slightly closer toward him. “Ah... or are you already trying your luck there? I heard you were in New York. Forgive me for dragging you back home just as you were trying to pitch yourself ... I miss you, my lovely son. Truly, I did...”

Kafka let out a long, heavy sigh. He genuinely lacked the energy to respond. Being bundled onto a jet and trapped in the air for seven straight hours had drained him completely.

Kafka closed his eyes for a brief moment, massaging his temples before speaking. “I understand. Just let me—”

Before Kafka could finish his sentence, Edward cut him off yet again. “I’ve had dreams about you, you know. On several occasions.”

Edward paused briefly, then pressed on.

“I desperately wanted to come to you, but I’m getting on in years and can’t manage to stand for too long anymore. I simply can’t travel long distances like you do, so ... I hope you’ll understand. I’m merely a father who misses his lovely son, that is all.”

Edward’s tone of voice right now could easily break down anyone’s defenses. That single coat of carefully structured phrasing was more than enough to make Kafka feel like a villain if he dared to kick him out.

“What is it that keeps you out there, son? Our home has a library, a gallery for fine art, even a room dedicated to musical instruments. What do you have out there that isn’t already under this roof? Name it, and I shall have the room built, we’ve plenty of land to spare,” Edward said again. “Sculptures? Ah ... right. I prefer paintings and you’re fond of sculptures. Very well, a dedicated room for your sculpture collection. What else, then? *Magazines?*”

The moment Edward mentioned it, Kafka’s hand twitched at his side before curling into a fist. A sinking feeling hit him right then.

“That is what people are into these days, isn’t it? Do people collect magazines the same way they do books, son? Right... a dedicated magazine room for you actually sounds rather good.”

Edward seemed positively thrilled, snapping his fingers before opening one of the drawers beside the bed.

Kafka's gaze shifted down from Edward's face to his hands, his father had successfully tapped into his deepest anxiety. Edward pulled out a few magazines from the drawer, nearly all of them belonged to Kafka, items that were supposed to be at his own place, not here.

Then, one particular issue made Kafka's eyes flicker ever so slightly. It was a magazine featuring a blonde girl on the cover, the one and only girl Kafka had been trying so desperately to shield from Edward, Cindy.

Edward stroked the cover gently before placing it on the table right in front of Kafka. "I brought it along, we could perhaps display it in our library later on. I noticed you collect these, and I figured its worth ought to be on par with my own book collection."

It wasn't. Kafka knew that wasn't the point at all. He could already tell Edward was about to bring up the girl.

Kafka's eyes remained fixed on the magazine covers as a fleeting thought crossed his mind—a one-in-a-ten chance, perhaps, that Edward hadn't realized. Maybe, just maybe, Edward had simply picked these up at random things from his house.

Yet, Kafka knew his father far too well. The man hadn't become Prime Minister by accident, that sharp intellect of his couldn't be silenced by anyone.

"Vinny? Windy? Ah ... what was her name again? Do refresh my memory. Old age makes it far too easy to forget names...." Edward spoke once more.

Kafka felt the breath catch in his throat, as if every last molecule of oxygen had been forcefully sucked out of the room, leaving him suffocating. Kafka pressed his lips into a thin line and said nothing.

He knew it was a trap. A man like Edward was immune to the wear of time. He could recall a person's name, address, and full identity without needing a single correction.

“Whatever her name may be...” Edward rose from the bed, stepping over to lean lightly against the table. “Looking at the way you rebel and defy me, it all made sense once I saw you dating that girl.”

There it was. The real point of this conversation.

Kafka tilted his head up slightly to look at his father. He recognized that face now. Not the warm, smiling facade. That cold, vacant expression was the only genuine face among Edward's endless collection of masks.

“Are you blissfully unaware that this girl frequents bars? She's damaged goods. She's only after your money, expecting you to sweep up the messes she leaves behind. I did warn you, those people back in America are a dreadful influence on you. You've no business associating with her.”

Kafka's brow furrowed. How on earth did his father know all this? No, more importantly, how deep did this go?

Before Kafka could piece together a response, Edward cut in yet again. “I realize you're hardly well-versed in matters of feelings, but do take a word of advice from me. I've encountered girls like her time and again. Their kind only ever lasts a single night, they haven't the slightest stomach for a domestic life.”

“Marrying her? Only in your wildest dreams. Do you honestly believe a girl like her could survive a life like ours? She'll simply carry on behind your back and walk out the second your money runs dry,” Edward added.

Kafka clenched his fists. Edward really pushed his buttons, yet he couldn't bring himself to refute every single word.

Yes. Perhaps he was right. Kafka himself wasn't even sure if Cindy could ever accept a family like his.

No, the problem wasn't Cindy.

It was his family.

Marriage? With a family like this? No sane girl would ever agree to it. Or at best, she might last a few months before running for the hills. And even then, Kafka couldn't possibly blame her.

Kafka grabbed the magazine and tossed it onto the floor beneath the table. It felt safer down there than sitting out in the open.

"It's over. I ended it," Kafka leaned forward, digging his fingernails into the armrest until his knuckles turned white. "She has nothing to do with me anymore."

Edward went silent for a moment before letting out a dry chuckle.

"Ah... so you really were with her then? I was merely taking a wild guess."

Kafka's brow furrowed. Had he just walked straight into a trap and exposed his own secret, or was Edward simply talking out of his arse? Either way, he had never considered the relationship much of a secret to begin with.

"Even if it is over, as long as that girl remains anywhere near your orbit, she'll be a dreadful influence," Edward continued smoothly. "You could still see her, stay at her apartment, or run off with her altogether. That is your plan, isn't it?"

"What on earth are you blathering about? I said it's over between me and her," Kafka snapped back. "Forget about your faulty memory, I reckon it's your ears that are completely broken."

Yet Edward only laughed harder, as though Kafka's retort were nothing more than a splendid joke. "If breaking things off once could settle a relationship forever, your mother and I would never have had an affair."

Kafka went silent, his mind racing as he tried to decipher his father's line of thought. Edward was so unpredictable, he could derail a conversation and steer it anywhere he pleased.

"You see... I married a woman consumed by power and wealth. Though I loved her at first, I regretted it in the end. So I am terrified that you might marry the wrong girl and suffer the very same regret down the line," Edward's eyes drifting toward the window.

"I regretted not staying with your mother, choosing the wrong person instead. I couldn't divorce her because she came from such an influential family—there were so many threats leveled against me back then..." Edward turned his gaze back to Kafka. "So I began seeing your mother in secret again. I knew it was wrong... yet she was my one true love. The only one who could accept me, flaws and all, she—"

"Keep your mouth shut," Kafka slammed his fist against the tabletop, the wood rattling under the force. "Denouncing other people's affairs as vile while romanticising your own is the most hypocritical rubbish I've ever heard."

Edward paused for a beat, then gave a slow nod. "I knew you wouldn't believe me. No matter. I understand why you despise it so much. But I do hope you don't hold it against your mother. She loves you dearly, even to this day."

With that, Edward stepped closer and gently cupped Kafka's face, stroking his cheeks for a brief moment before offering a sweet, disarming smile.

"We shall have dinner together tonight. I'll have the staff prepare your favorite dishes," he said before turning and leaving the room.

The moment the door clicked shut, Kafka drew a deep, ragged breath. He clutched his chest, a suffocating tightness always seized him whenever he spoke to his father, as if he had been holding his breath the entire time the man was near. His hands trembled slightly, but he balled them into tight fists, forcing the fear back down through sheer willpower.

“Huh? What did he mean *to this day*?” Kafka muttered under his breath.

The weight of those words only just struck him. Hadn't his mother passed away giving birth to him? That was what the old household staff had told him when he was a boy. Kafka replayed the sentence over and over in his head. It felt profoundly wrong to speak of someone long dead as though she were still very much alive.
